

BEFORE

Settled life in Mesopotamia dates back 10,000 years. A rich archaeological record documents the growth of irrigation, agriculture, trade, writing, towns, and complex societies.

EARLY SETTLEMENT

Farming began

c. 8000 BCE in the case of

Halaf culture << 44–45 in the north and

c. 6000 BCE in the southern, **Ubaid culture**.

IRRIGATION AND ORGANIZATION

Settlements grew due to **irrigation programs**.

The surplus crops grown were traded, **creating wealth**. The organization and control needed resulted in more complex, **layered societies**.

THE RISE OF URBAN CENTERS

By the 3000s BCE, the first **urban centers** were in place << 44–45, with the southern **Sumer** region home to a thriving civilization by 3500 BCE.

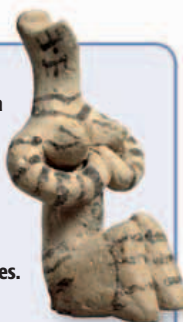
FROM TRADING TO WRITING

The record-keeping needed to control trade used seals featuring symbols and pictures, followed by the development of early writing 62–63 >>.



SEAL SHOWING PLOWING WITH AN OX

HALAF
POTTERY FIGURE



The civilization of Mesopotamia thrived across an area that today includes Iraq, southwest Iran, east Syria, and southeast Turkey. Mesopotamia is Greek for “between rivers”—civilization here rested on a prime position between the Euphrates and Tigris rivers. This dependence on rivers echoes that of three other civilizations: those in contemporary Egypt (see pp.56–57) and the Indus Valley (see pp.58–59), and in China a little later (see pp.60–61).

As in Egypt, Mesopotamian crops relied on rich silts deposited by the river waters, while marshlands provided fish and waterfowl for eating, and reeds—used for roofing and baskets in Mesopotamia. Irrigation and land-reclamation programs required well-drilled marshalling of large numbers of people. This laid the foundations for what is thought to be the world’s first stratified (layered)

**Tomb treasure**

The lavish jewels worn by Queen Pu-abi (Ur, c. 2500 BCE) feature precious metals and semiprecious stones from Ur’s varied trading partners.

society—reaching its height of sophistication slightly ahead of Egypt.

City-states and empires

By around 3000 BCE, Mesopotamia was entering an era known as the Early Dynastic, which lasted 700 years. Civilization was focused initially on city-states in the south, an area often called Sumer after the Sumerian language widely spoken there. The pattern of Mesopotamia’s history emerged at this stage: cities and city-states (see p.94), often linked by trading and diplomatic ties, would cooperate and compete, rise and fall. Certain city-states and city-based dynasties—Uruk, Kish, Akkad, and Ur—rose to control others for a while before being dominated by yet others.

This contrasts with Egypt and its centralized rule, but bears some similarity to the later life of the Greek city-states (see pp.94–95). Great cities of the third millennium included Ur, Lagash, Kish, Eridu, and Uruk

One figure is shown larger than everyone else. It is likely that this is the king, glass in hand, at his court, with this top row depicting a banquet scene.



The Cradle of Civilization

Mesopotamia, a fertile land embraced by rivers, was the site of the first complex societies. By 3000 BCE, competing city-states of great wealth and sophistication were flourishing here, with advanced irrigation and agricultural schemes, established trade, the first known writing, and grand palaces and temples.

EMPEROR, DIED c. 2284 BCE

SARGON OF AKKAD

Seen traditionally as a great warrior-king, Sargon established the Akkadian dynasty and ruled c. 2340–2284 BCE. He founded his capital city, Akkad, and created a centralized state that oversaw the first real empire in Mesopotamia. Few tales about Sargon can be verified. It has been suggested that he established

himself as a successful independent ruler first and then began his expansionist policies. His military prowess could be explained by Akkadian techniques being more efficient than those of rival armies. We know about Sargon’s rule from an ancient document called the Sumerian King List.

BRONZE CAST HEAD, 2334–2154 BCE, OF AN AKKADIAN RULER, PROBABLY SARGON

